

SUBSCRIBER HELP · REVIEW & CONCEPT

Every subscriber, to the **right place**, first time.

A review of how DC Thomson subscribers find help today, a full concept for a subscriber help centre across your titles, and an 8-week pilot to prove it on one title.

01 Summary	02 DC Thomson today	03 Subscriber journey review	04 Help centre concept
05 Routing & cancellations	06 Subscriber video	07 8-week pilot	+ Full concept page (separate PDF)

Dear DC Thomson team,

Your subscribers are loyal. The DC Thomson Shop scores 4.8 out of 5 on Trustpilot, and some of your titles have been part of readers' lives for generations. Growing digital subscriptions is now central to your transformation, and every subscriber you keep counts towards that.

We looked at how a subscriber finds help today, as someone whose Saturday paper didn't arrive or who wants to change how they pay. The help exists: a help centre, My Account, and teams who clearly care. **But subscribers aren't guided to it.** On dcthomson.co.uk the only subscriber action we could find is a cancellation form. Readers choose between four phone lines with different opening hours, and the same few questions keep coming back.

reChanneld is channel-strategy software from Helsinki. It gives every title one “How can we help?” front door that shows each subscriber the fastest route for their need: self-service, a guide, a form or the right team. It sits on top of the systems you already have.

Rather than describe it, we've done some of the work:

1

Journey review

10 findings and a scorecard of today's subscriber help experience.

2

Help centre concept

A full-page concept across your titles, with 11 annotated ideas.

3

Pilot plan

8 weeks on one title, with clear KPIs, so you can decide with your own data.

We'd love 20 minutes with your customer experience or subscriptions lead to walk through it and hear where subscriber help hurts most today.

Kind regards,

Touko Laakkonen

Service Channel Strategy, reChanneld · [e-mail] · [phone]

A transformation built on subscribers

A family business with a 200-year heritage, now putting money into technology, data and AI to grow digital subscriptions and B2B products.

£41M

subscription revenue, FY to Mar 2025 (+1%)

50,000+

paying subscribers to regional news titles

75,000

the earlier digital-subscription target for 2025

4.8/5

Trustpilot score for the DC Thomson Shop

Recent milestones

- **FY 2025** Revenue level at ~£134 M like-for-like, pre-tax profit £31 M, advertising +14%.
- **May 2025** Ella Dolphin appointed Deputy CEO, with a focus on M&A and transformation across the portfolio.
- **2025** Air Business renewed on a 3-year contract for subscription management.
- **May 2026** AI narration (BeyondWords × Pugpig) added to the Stylist and Press and Journal apps.
- **Now** Regional news subscribers past 50,000, still short of the 75,000 ambition.

What this means for subscriber help

- **Keeping subscribers counts as much as winning them.** Each frustrated subscriber is a churn risk on the £41 M line.
- **The portfolio is broad.** News, magazines, kids and puzzles each have their own readers, and one set of help rules across all of them would save effort.
- **You buy focused tools.** The AI narration shows you add specialist partners rather than rebuild your platforms. reChanneld fits that pattern.
- **Your systems are already in place.** Air Business, My Account and the help centre stay. What's missing is the guidance layer that connects subscribers to them.

The opportunity: make the help you already have the first thing every subscriber finds.

Finding help today: 10 findings

Reviewed as a subscriber with a missing paper or a billing question, 2 October 2026. These scores are our view.

2/10

FINDING HELP

3/10CLEAR CONTACT
ROUTES**3/10**SELF-SERVICE
SIGNPOSTING**4/10**OUT-OF-HOURS
HELP**3/10**OPTIONS AT
CANCELLATION**9/10**SUBSCRIBER
TRUST

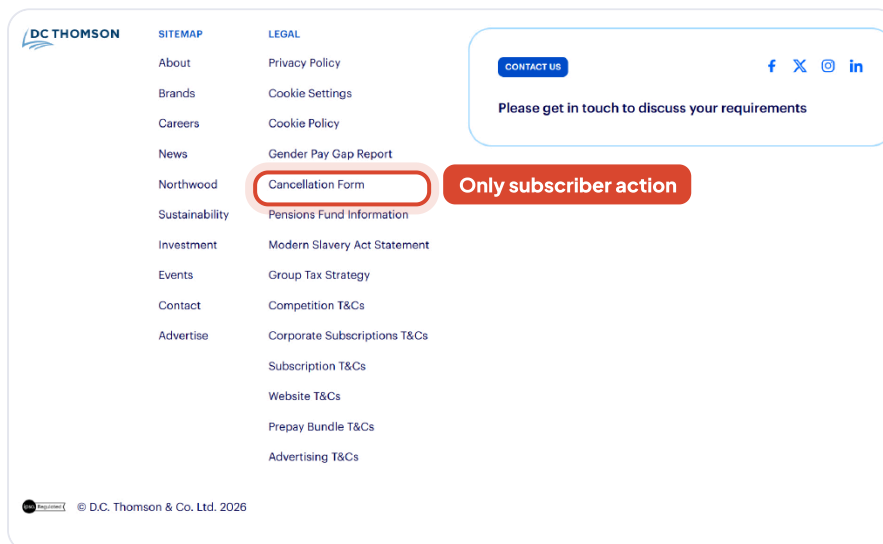
01 No path for subscribers in the main navigation **CRITICAL**

The menu serves advertisers, investors, job seekers and partners: About, Brands, Careers, News, Northwood, Sustainability, Investment, Events, Contact and Advertise. There's no "Help" or "My subscription".

→ Add "Help & subscriptions" to the main navigation.

02 The one subscriber action in the footer is "Cancellation Form" **CRITICAL**

It sits among the legal links, with no "Manage", "Pause" or "Report a missing issue" next to it. Cancelling is the easiest subscriber action to find.



→ A "Subscribers" footer column, with cancellation inside it.

03 The Contact box is written for business enquiries **HIGH**

"Please get in touch to discuss your requirements" suits an advertiser. A reader with a missing issue doesn't recognise themselves in it.

→ Start with "How can we help?" and let visitors pick: subscriber, advertiser, press or careers.

04 Four phone lines, chosen by title and topic **HIGH**

Courier digital, Press and Journal digital, home delivery and the magazine shop each have their own number. The subscriber has to do the routing.

→ Ask for the title and topic, then show the right route, and the right number if a call is needed.

03 · SUBSCRIBER JOURNEY REVIEW, CONTINUED

05 Different hours on each line, and none on Sundays **HIGH**

News digital lines are open Mon–Fri 8–18 and Sat 9–17. The magazine shop is open Mon–Fri 9–17. A reader who finds a problem on a Sunday evening has nowhere to go.

→ Self-service answers 24/7, with honest “we’re back at…” messages.

06 The same questions keep coming back **MEDIUM**

Despite the 4.8/5 rating, negative reviews cluster around late or missing issues, monthly vs quarterly billing, refunds and early renewal reminders.

→ Make these the top self-service tasks, available in two clicks.

07 Self-service exists but isn't signposted **MEDIUM**

There's a help centre and My Account through Air Business, but the corporate homepage doesn't lead to either.

→ Put the help front door on every title page, every app and every subscriber e-mail.

08 Brand cards lead to brand pages, not to help **MEDIUM**

A People's Friend or Puzzler reader who clicks their title arrives at the brand story, not at subscriber help.

→ Give each title a “Help & subscriptions” entry, with the same journey everywhere.

09 Cancellation is shown without alternatives **MEDIUM**

Some subscribers who cancel only want a break, a cheaper option or a problem fixed. From the footer, they're offered only the form.

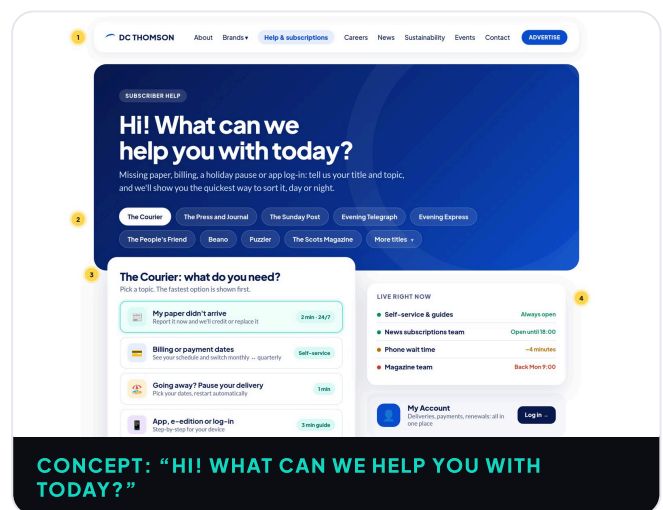
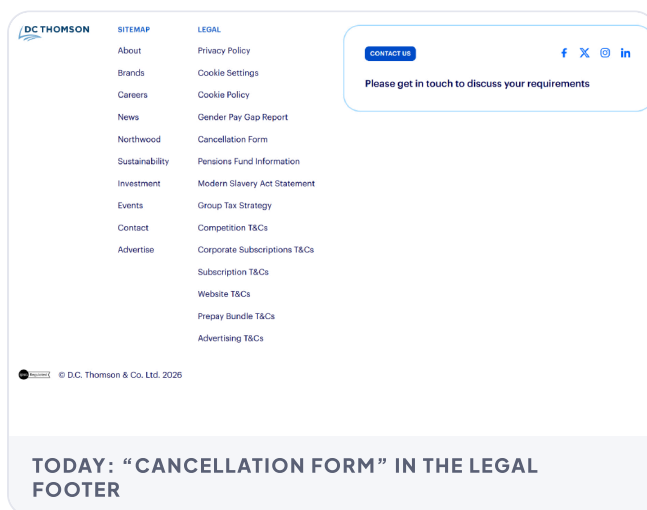
→ Show pause, switch to digital and talk to us next to cancel. Cancel stays one click away.

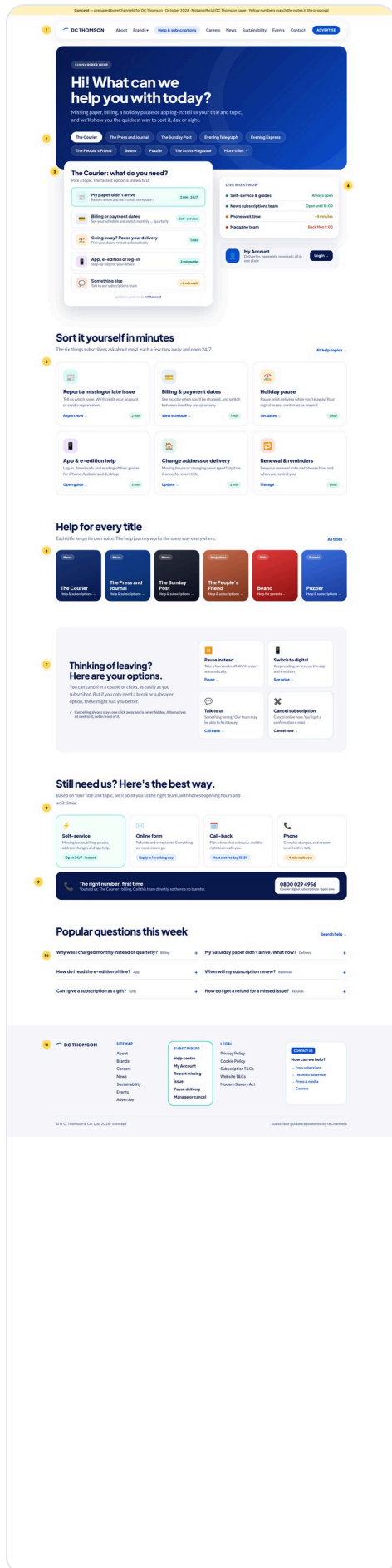
10 No wait times before you call **LOW**

Subscribers can't see whether a line is open or busy until they dial.

→ Show live status and wait times in the help front door.

Before → after





One front door for every subscriber, on every title

The full page is in [reChanneld-DC-Thomson-Help-Concept.pdf](#) (1440 px, high resolution). Each yellow number matches one of these notes.

- 1 **“Help & subscriptions” in the main navigation.** Subscribers get a visible path. Fixes 01.
- 2 **Pick your title first.** The Courier, Press and Journal, Sunday Post, People's Friend, Beano, Puzzler and more. One journey, tailored per title. Fixes 04 and 08.
- 3 **The reChanneld front door.** Topics, with the fastest route highlighted and honest times shown, such as “2 min · 24/7” or “~4 min wait”.
- 4 **Live status.** Which teams are open now, current wait times, and when closed teams are back. Fixes 05 and 10.
- 5 **Six top self-service tasks** taken straight from the recurring contact reasons: missing issue, billing, pause, app, address and renewal. Fixes 06 and 07.
- 6 **Help for every title.** Each brand keeps its own look and voice, and the help journey works the same way everywhere.
- 7 **“Thinking of leaving?”** Pause, switch to digital or talk to us, shown next to a clear one-click cancel. Fixes 09 and stays in line with UK easy-cancellation expectations.
- 8 **“Still need us?”** The channels ranked for the subscriber's topic: self-service, form, call-back or phone, each with its status.
- 9 **The right number, first time.** If a call is needed, reChanneld shows the right line for that title and topic, so the call doesn't need transferring.
- 10 **Popular questions this week,** updated from live data on what subscribers actually ask about.
- 11 **A “Subscribers” footer column** and a Contact box that asks “How can we help?”. Fixes 02 and 03.

Kept on purpose

DC Thomson's navy and royal blue, rounded cards and calm tone. This is an evolution of your current site, not a redesign, and the help front door can go live on one title first.

Proposed starting rules

Built from public reviews and contact pages. In a pilot, your own contact data sets the final rules.

SUBSCRIBER TOPIC	ROUTE FIRST TO	WHY
Paper or magazine didn't arrive	Self-service	A recurring complaint. A form plus an automatic credit or replacement takes 2 minutes, 24/7, with no call needed.
Billing date or frequency	My Account	Shows the payment schedule clearly and prevents the monthly vs quarterly surprise behind several complaints.
Holiday pause / address change	Self-service	Simple, high volume and seasonal. It takes the pressure off before summer and Christmas.
App, e-edition or log-in	Guide	Step-by-step instructions by device, with a call-back as the fallback.
Renewal timing and reminders	My Account	Lets subscribers choose when and how they're reminded, answering the "too early" complaint.
Refund or complaint	Form – team	A structured form arrives with every detail, so the agent can resolve it in one touch.
Cancel or downgrade	Options + team	Pause, switch and talk shown next to one-click cancel. The team's time is protected for these conversations.

Cancellation, done right

UK subscription rules point towards cancellation being as easy as signing up. We agree: blocking cancellation damages trust and invites complaints.

What a front door can do is **offer the right alternative at the right moment**: a pause for the reader who's going away, a cheaper digital option for one watching costs, and a call-back for one with a problem. Cancel stays one click away.

How rules are set

- By **title**: news, magazines and Beano can have different routes
- By **topic**, the subscriber's own choice
- By **time**: different routes in and out of office hours
- By **queue**: steer to self-service when lines are busy
- Changed by your CX team in minutes, with no IT ticket needed

“Sorted in two minutes”: a 45-second help video

New help routes only work if subscribers know about them. A short, friendly video can sit in the help centre, renewal e-mails, the app and title social channels. It's made once, with a version for each title.

0:00–0:06 Saturday morning ☕ Doorstep... no paper 📰 ? VISUAL A reader opens the door: no Courier today. <i>“Paper didn’t turn up? We’ve all been there.”</i>	0:06–0:16 📱 “Help & subscriptions” → The Courier → Missing paper VISUAL On her phone: pick the title, pick the topic. <i>“Just tell us your title and what’s wrong.”</i>	0:16–0:26 ✓ Reported · credit added 1 min 48 s VISUAL Done before the kettle boils. <i>“Sorted in two minutes, any day, any time.”</i>
0:26–0:34 ⏸ Pause · 💳 Billing · 📱 App VISUAL Quick montage of the other top tasks. <i>“Holidays, billing, app help: it’s all there.”</i>	0:34–0:40 ☎ The right team, first time VISUAL A friendly agent with an older reader on the phone. <i>“And when you’d rather talk, we’ll put you straight through to the right person.”</i>	0:40–0:45 [Title] · Help & subscriptions yourtitle.co.uk/help VISUAL End card in the title's own branding. <i>“Help and subscriptions. We’re here for you.”</i>

Formats

16:9 for the help centre, 9:16 for social and the app, a 15-second e-mail cut and a GIF. Captioned for viewing without sound.

Per title, from one master

The same story with different end cards and voice-over lines for The Courier, Press and Journal, People's Friend and more. One production, many versions.

Prove it on one title, with your own data

The suggested pilot title is The Courier: a high-volume news title with a dedicated subscriptions line.

WEEKS 1–2

Map

Review three months of contact reasons. Agree the top topics, routes and wording, and set the baseline.

WEEKS 3–8

Guide

The front door goes live on The Courier's help pages and subscriber e-mails, with A/B tests on the top five topics.

WEEK 9

Decide

Review the results together, then decide on a rollout to other titles in priority order.

What we'll measure

KPI	HOW
Calls per 1,000 subscribers	Phone data, before vs during
Self-service share by topic	reChanneld analytics
Out-of-hours help	Sessions outside office hours
Missing-issue handling time	Form to resolution
Cancellations converted to pause/switch	Choices in the cancel flow
Subscriber satisfaction	A one-click rating after each route

Who does what

reChanneld

- Set-up, routing rules and copy
- Analytics dashboard and weekly check-ins
- A/B tests and a final report

DC Thomson

- One CX contact, about 2 hours a week
- Three months of contact-reason data
- Adding the front door to The Courier's help pages

No new chatbot, no CRM change, and no change to Air Business. **If it doesn't show results in 8 weeks, you stop.**

Better choices. Happier customers.

reChanneld is channel-strategy software from Helsinki, Finland. It uses behavioural science, such as clear defaults, honest wait times and positive framing, to help customers choose the best channel for their need.

Customer service teams set it up themselves. It works with the systems they already have: help centres, account portals, contact centres and chatbots.

S-Bank, one of Finland's largest banks (3.3 million customers, around a million interactions a year), uses reChanneld alongside its chatbot to guide customers to the right channel, 24/7.

79%

of contacts typically guided to the client's preferred channel

24/7

guidance, including when teams are offline

0

systems to replace



Made in Finland, built with Nordic banks and insurers

Five nudges in every front door



Smart defaults

The best option comes first.



Honest times

Real waits and hours.



Social proof

"Most readers sort this online."



Fewer choices

Four options, not twenty.



Positive framing

"Done in 2 minutes."

Next step

A 20-minute call with your customer experience or subscriptions lead. We'll show a live demo, walk through the concept page and agree whether The Courier is the right pilot title.

Shall we take 20 minutes?

We'd love to hear how subscriber help works today, and where it hurts most.

Touko Laakkonen
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